2026

GIM Nation Branding, Risk, and Global Investing

MOROCCO

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A Strategic 2026 Overview

As of early 2026, the Kingdom of Morocco continues to distinguish itself as a pillar of stability and a primary economic engine in North Africa. Driven by a long-term royal vision, the nation is successfully navigating a transition toward a high-value, diversified economy while maintaining a pragmatic and influential role on the global diplomatic stage.

1. Political Landscape and Governance

Morocco is a constitutional monarchy where **King Mohammed VI** retains significant executive and spiritual authority. While the 2011 constitutional reforms transferred some powers to the elected parliament, the "Makhzen" (the royal palace and its advisors) remains the ultimate arbiter of major strategic, security, and religious policies.

Internal Stability and Governance

- **Political Continuity:** The current government, led by Prime Minister **Aziz Akhannouch** (Rassemblement National des Indépendants - RNI), maintains a pro-business, center-right coalition that has been in power since 2021.
- **Upcoming Elections:** National legislative elections are scheduled for **September 2026**, which will test the government's ability to address persistent social grievances regarding the cost of living and unemployment.
- **Social Reform:** The "Social State" model remains a priority, with the 2026 budget allocating approximately **$15 billion** (140 billion dirhams) to healthcare and education—a 16% increase intended to reduce regional inequalities and modernize public services.
- **Challenges:** Despite its stability, Morocco faces criticism from international bodies regarding civil liberties and the slow pace of translating formal democratic processes into "real democratic impact".

Foreign Policy and Regional Strategy

- **Western Sahara:** Morocco's sovereignty over the Western Sahara remains the cornerstone of its diplomacy. Major powers including the U.S., Spain, and France have recently affirmed support for the Moroccan autonomy plan, strengthening Rabat’s regional position.

- **Strategic Alliances:** Morocco remains a key "exporter of peace" and a critical security partner for the West. It continues to deepen ties with the **European Union** through the "Pact for the Mediterranean" (launched Nov 2025) and maintains its commitment to the **Abraham Accords**.
- **Atlantic Initiative:** The kingdom is actively positioning itself as a gateway to the Atlantic for landlocked Sahel nations, promoting regional integration and maritime cooperation.

2. Economic Situation and Outlook

Morocco's economy is projected to be one of the most dynamic in the region for 2026, with GDP growth estimates ranging between **3.7% and 4.9%**.

Macroeconomic Performance

- **Resilient Growth:** Following a strong recovery in 2025 (4.8% growth), the 2026 outlook is buoyed by a significant rebound in the **agricultural sector** due to exceptional rainfall and continued strength in non-agricultural industries.
- **Controlled Inflation:** Inflation has largely stabilized, with 2026 forecasts projecting a decline to roughly **1.3%**, providing a predictable environment for both households and investors.
- **Fiscal Consolidation:** The government is successfully narrowing its fiscal deficit, targeting **3% of GDP by 2026**, supported by improved tax revenues and fiscal reforms.

Key Drivers of the Economy

- **Industrial Acceleration:** Morocco is now a global hub for **automotive and aerospace** manufacturing. The automotive sector, in particular, is a primary pillar of growth, with expanding supply chains for electric vehicles (EVs).
- **Infrastructure & 2030 World Cup:** Massive public investment (projected at **$38 billion** for 2026) is being funneled into ports, airports, and high-speed rail projects in preparation for hosting the **2030 FIFA World Cup**.
- **Tourism & Remittances:** Tourism is "booming," with arrivals expected to grow by 20% in 2026, further supported by the momentum from the Africa Cup of

Nations. Remittances from the Moroccan diaspora continue to contribute approximately 8% of GDP.

- **Energy Transition:** Morocco is a regional leader in **renewable energy**, with a target of 52% capacity from renewables by 2030 and significant new investments in green hydrogen and solar infrastructure.

Summary of Economic Projections (2026)

Indicator	Projected Value
Real GDP Growth	4.2% – 4.9%
Inflation (CPI)	~1.3%
Fiscal Deficit	3.0% of GDP
Primary Growth Driver	Agriculture & Public Investment

Morocco's economic future is defined by a shift from traditional agriculture and phosphate dependence toward becoming a high-tech global hub for **green energy** and **advanced manufacturing**.

1. A Green Energy Superpower

Morocco is moving beyond domestic solar projects to become a major exporter of "green molecules" to Europe.

- **Green Hydrogen Hub**: The government recently launched the "Morocco Offer," selecting five massive projects worth approximately **$32 billion** to produce green hydrogen, ammonia, and synthetic fuels.
- **Decarbonized Industry**: Global giants like OCP Group are investing **$13 billion** to achieve full green ammonia self-sufficiency by 2027, effectively "de-risking" the market for future renewable investors.
- **Gigawatt Projects**: Initiatives like the **Chbika project** aim to combine 1 GW of solar and wind power to generate 200,000 tonnes of green hydrogen annually.

2. The Electric Vehicle (EV) Pivot

Morocco is rapidly transforming its top-ranked African automotive industry into a continental leader for electric mobility.

- **Gigafactory Launch**: A **$1.28 billion gigafactory** is set to begin production in 2026, targeting an initial capacity of 20 GWh of EV batteries.
- **First Homegrown EV**: Local manufacturer Neo Motors plans to begin full production of the **"Dial-E"** in 2026, the country's first fully locally developed electric car, priced at approximately **$11,000**.
- **Supply Chain Integration**: Major investments are flowing into the battery supply chain, including a **$2.2 billion** investment in components and cathode production to serve European markets.

3. The "World Cup Effect" (2030)

Co-hosting the **2030 FIFA World Cup** is acting as a massive 10-year catalyst for national infrastructure.

- **Massive Infrastructure Spend**: Total planned investments leading up to 2030 exceed **$230 billion**, covering high-speed rail extensions, airport upgrades, and modernized sports facilities.
- **Flagship Projects**: Construction is underway for the **Grand Stade Hassan II**, which will be the world's largest football stadium with a capacity of 115,000.
- **Digital Transformation**: Preparations include a nationwide 5G rollout, aiming to cover **25% of the population by 2026** and 70% by 2030.

4. Strategic Atlantic Gateway

The **Atlantic Initiative** aims to position Morocco as the primary maritime outlet for landlocked Sahel nations.

- **Deepwater Ports**: The Dakhla Atlantic Port (estimated at **$1.7 billion**) is a key pillar of this strategy, intended to anchor regional trade and logistics.
- **Trade Openness**: Morocco is projected to significantly improve its global trade ranking through the full implementation of the **African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA)**.

Casablanca

Casablanca is the **largest city in Morocco** and serves as the country's primary economic, financial, and industrial hub. Located on the Atlantic coast, it is a bustling, modern metropolis often referred to as "the White City" (its name literally translates to "White House" in Spanish). While many travelers use it as a transit point due to its major international airport, it offers a unique fusion of traditional Moroccan heritage and a cosmopolitan, Western-influenced lifestyle

- Casablanca is Morocco's modern economic hub, often described as more cosmopolitan and "Western-feeling" than traditional cities like Marrakech or Fez. While it serves as a major entry point for international travelers, it is a living city of nearly 4 million people rather than a purely tourist-centric destination.
- **Arrival & Transport:** The Mohammed V International Airport (CMN) is the main gateway. The most efficient way to reach the city center is by train, which departs hourly from the terminal and takes 35–45 minutes. Within the city, use the modern CasaTramway for long distances or red petit taxis for short trips; always ensure the driver uses the meter (*compteur*).
- **Money**: The official currency is the **Moroccan Dirham (MAD)**. Currently 1 United States Dollar equals ~9.28 Moroccan Dirham.
    - While high-end hotels and restaurants accept cards, Casablanca remains a **cash-based society** for taxis, markets, and small shops.

    - The **Moroccan Dirham (MAD)** is the official currency. It is a "closed currency," meaning you cannot easily exchange it outside Morocco; export of Dirhams is prohibited.
    - **Cash is king** for small purchases, tips, and *petits taxis*.
    - **Credit cards** (Visa/Mastercard) are widely accepted in major hotels, international chains, and upscale restaurants. Use ATMs located inside banks or high-traffic areas during daylight to avoid fraud.
- **Language**: **Darija** (Moroccan Arabic) is the primary language, but **French** is widely used in business. English is common in tourist sectors but less so elsewhere.
- **Culture, Business Norms & Safety**
    - **Dress Code:** Casablanca is relatively liberal, but modest dress is still recommended to avoid unwanted attention and show respect. Both men and women should cover their shoulders and knees when visiting religious sites like the Hassan II Mosque.
    - **Safety:** Casablanca is generally safe for travelers, though petty crime like pickpocketing occurs in crowded areas like the Old Medina. It is advised to avoid walking alone in poorly lit or deserted areas at night.
    - **Dining:** For authentic experiences, visit the Marché Central for fresh seafood cooked on the spot. Rick's Café is a popular (though touristy) recreation of the famous film setting.
    - **Etiquette:** Moroccan culture is hospitable but conservative. Dress "business casual" or modest (covering shoulders and knees) to show respect.
    - **Language:** French is the primary language of business and administration; Darija (Moroccan Arabic) is used for daily life. English is common in top-tier hotels and among younger professionals.
    - **Religion:** Most mosques are closed to non-Muslims, with the Hassan II Mosque being a notable exception (guided tours available outside prayer times).
    - **Social Graces:** Political discussions, particularly regarding the monarchy or Western Sahara, should be avoided. Expect business meetings to move at a slower, relationship-focused pace—patience is a virtue.

Marrakesh

Marrakesh is often called the "Red City" because of the distinct pigment used in its sandstone buildings and ramparts. Located at the foot of the Atlas Mountains, it is the cultural heart of Morocco—a place where ancient North African traditions collide with modern luxury.

The Layout: Old vs. New

The city is split into two distinct worlds:

The Medina (Old City): A UNESCO World Heritage site and a fortified labyrinth of narrow alleys. This is where you'll find the famous souks (markets), historic palaces, and hidden riads (traditional houses with interior courtyards).

Gueliz (New City): Built during the French protectorate, this area feels like a modern European city with wide boulevards, high-end boutiques, art galleries, and trendy cafes.

Top Things to Experience

- Jemaa el-Fnaa: The main square and the city's pulsing heart. By day, it's filled with orange juice stalls and henna artists; by night, it transforms into a massive open-air kitchen with smoke rising from food stalls and circles of musicians and storytellers.

- Jardin Majorelle: A stunning botanical garden created by French painter Jacques Majorelle and later restored by Yves Saint Laurent. It's famous for its vibrant "Majorelle Blue" buildings.
- Koutoubia Mosque: The city's largest mosque. Its 12th-century minaret is the tallest structure in the medina and serves as a natural compass for travelers.
- Bahia Palace: A 19th-century masterpiece of Moroccan architecture, featuring intricate tilework (zellij), carved cedarwood, and lush gardens.
- The Souks: A sensory overload where you can find everything from hand-woven rugs and leather goods to mounds of colorful spices and lanterns.

Culture & Flavor

- The Food: Don't leave without trying Tagine (slow-cooked stew), Tanjia (a Marrakesh specialty cooked in clay jars), and endless glasses of fresh mint tea.
- The Hammam: A traditional steam bath and scrub that is a cornerstone of Moroccan life.
- The Vibe: It is chaotic, colorful, and loud, but most riads offer a "zen" escape from the street noise the moment you step inside.

Practical Tips

Haggling: In the souks, price negotiation is expected and considered a social interaction.

Timing: Spring (March–May) and Autumn (September–November) are the best times to visit to avoid the extreme summer heat.

Dress: While Marrakesh is quite international, it's respectful to dress modestly (covering shoulders and knees) when exploring the Medina.

General Information

Weather:

In mid-to-late March, Casablanca experiences mild, spring-like weather as it transitions out of its cool season. Daytime temperatures typically range from **65°F to 68°F (18°C–20°C)**, while evenings remain cool, dropping to **52°F to 55°F (11°C–13°C)**.

- **Rainfall:** March is at the tail end of the rainy season. While generally mild, there is roughly an 18% chance of a wet day. Rainfall typically occurs in short, light showers totaling about 1.4 to 2.0 inches for the month.

Because temperatures fluctuate between sunny afternoons and chilly coastal evenings, layering is essential.

Daytime: Light trousers or jeans paired with t-shirts or long-sleeved tops.

Evening: A warm sweater, fleece, or light jacket is necessary for outdoor dining or walks.

Accessories: Bring a light raincoat or umbrella for occasional showers and sunglasses for the frequent bright spells.

Visas:

U.S. citizens do not need a visa to enter Morocco for tourism or business stays of up to 90 days. Upon arrival, your passport will simply be given an entry stamp by immigration officials, which marks the beginning of your 90-day period.

US Citizen Entry Requirements

- Even without a visa, you must meet the following documentation standards to be admitted:
- Passport Validity: Your passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your date of entry.
- Blank Pages: You must have at least one blank page available for the entry stamp.
- Onward Travel: You may be asked to show proof of a return or onward ticket.
- Proof of Funds: Border officials may occasionally request evidence of sufficient financial means to support your stay.
- Condition: Ensure your passport is in good condition; travelers with damaged passports (torn pages or water damage) may be denied entry.

Visas – Non-US Citizens: Please research your requirements to confirm the following:

See https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Visa_policy_of_Morocco

China: Chinese citizens do not need a visa to visit Morocco for tourism or business stays of up to 90 days.

While a visa is not required, you must still meet these standard entry conditions:

- **Passport Validity:** Your ordinary passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your intended stay.
- **Blank Pages**: At least one blank page is required in your passport for the entry stamp.
- **Proof of Onward Travel**: You should be prepared to show a confirmed return or onward flight ticket.

- **Supporting Documents**: It is recommended to have proof of accommodation (hotel reservation) and sufficient funds to cover your stay
- **Documents to Carry:** Hotel bookings, return flight tickets, and proof of funds (€70+ per day).

India: Indian passport holders need a visa to visit Morocco for tourism or business. The easiest option is the electronic visa (e-Visa), which allows a stay of up to 30 days and takes 24–72 hours to process. There is no visa-on-arrival, so you must secure a visa before traveling.

Key Information for Indian Citizens:

e-Visa Eligibility: Available for Indian citizens holding a valid visa or residence permit from the USA, UK, Schengen Area, Canada, Australia, Ireland, or New Zealand.

How to Apply: Apply online via the official Moroccan e-Visa portal.

Requirements: A passport with at least 6 months validity, confirmed return tickets, and proof of accommodation/funds

Canada: Canadian citizens do not need a visa to visit Morocco for tourism or business stays of less than 90 days. You must hold a valid Canadian passport (valid for at least six months beyond your arrival date) and, in some cases, proof of accommodation or return/onward tickets

Mexico: Mexican citizens do not need a visa to visit Morocco for tourism or short-term stays of up to 90 days. A valid passport with at least 6 months validity from the entry date, proof of return/onward travel, and proof of sufficient funds are required for entry.

Health and Safety

EMERGENCY INFO:

For emergency services in Morocco, dial 19 (police).

From cell phone, use: 112

HEALTH & MEDICAL:

No mandatory vaccinations are required for entry unless arriving from a yellow fever zone. CDC recommends being up-to-date on routine shots (MMR, Tdap) plus Hepatitis A and Typhoid.

Always carry your prescription medication in original packaging, along with your doctor's prescription. Check with the Government of Morocco Ministry of Foreign Affairs to ensure the medication is legal in Morocco.

USE BOTTLED WATER FOR DRINKING AND BRUSHING TEETH --- Water Quality & Food Safety: In many areas, tap water is not potable. Bottled water and beverages are generally safe. Many restaurants and hotels serve tap water unless bottled water is specifically requested. Be aware that ice for drinks may be made using tap water.

TRANSPORTATION

Rideshare Apps: Rideshare apps operate in a legal gray zone across Morocco. Rideshare drivers and passengers have reported harassment and physical violence by taxi drivers. Travelers should exercise caution if traveling via rideshare apps, especially around hotels, airports, convention centers, and other locations frequented by taxi drivers.

- The most common and effective rideshare apps in Morocco are **InDrive**, **Careem**, and **WinkTaxi**. InDrive is widely used and allows passengers to set their own fare, while Careem operates in cities like Casablanca, Rabat, and Tangier. Note that, despite some reports of a return, Uber's status can be inconsistent, and traditional taxis are still the most common, though they often require negotiation.
- Download one of
- Key Rideshare Apps in Morocco:
- InDrive: Extremely popular (holding a large share of the market) and often cheaper than taxis. It works well in cities like Marrakech.
- Careem: Operates in major cities like Casablanca, Rabat, and Tangier.
- Alternative: Traditional "Petits Taxis" are available in all cities (red in Casablanca/Agadir, blue in Rabat/Tangier, orange in Marrakech) and are usually metered. Ensure the driver turns on their meter.

Important Tips for Ridesharing in Morocco:

- Legality/Tensions: InDrive is widely used but can face issues with local taxi drivers and police, as some consider it illegal.

- Cash Only: Most apps, particularly InDrive, require cash payment, as drivers often do not take cards.
- It is generally safe to use the Careem or InDrive apps in Casablanca, Morocco, as it provides a secure, monitored alternative to local taxis with transparent pricing. While considered safe for passengers, be aware that these services operate in a legal grey area, and tensions exist with traditional taxi drivers, making it best to avoid pickups near, for example, major taxi stands.

Key Tips for Using Careem/InDrive in Casablanca:

Safety: Careem is considered a reliable option for avoiding common tourist scams with local taxis.

Legal Status: Ride-hailing apps lack clear regulation in Morocco, which can sometimes lead to issues with traditional, licensed taxi drivers.

Airport Transfer: It is generally better to book a private transfer for airport pickups (CMN) rather than relying on apps, though using them for drop-offs is okay.

Vehicle Match: Always check that the car plate and driver details match the information in your app

Safety & Health

- **General Safety**: Casablanca is generally safe for business travelers, but exercise "increased caution" due to a Level 2 travel advisory. **Petty theft** (phone-snatching, pickpocketing) is the most common risk in crowded areas like the Old Medina or on public transit.

- **Health**:
    - **No mandatory vaccinations** are required for entry unless arriving from a yellow fever zone. CDC recommends being up-to-date on routine shots (MMR, Tdap) plus **Hepatitis A and Typhoid**.
    - **Water Safety**: Do **not drink tap water**; stick to bottled water for drinking and brushing teeth to avoid gastrointestinal issues.
- **Solo/Female Travelers**: Women should dress modestly and avoid walking alone in poorly lit or isolated areas at night.

Cultural & Business Norms

- **Etiquette**: Moroccan culture is hospitable but conservative. Dress "business casual" or modest (covering shoulders and knees) to show respect.
- **Language**: **French** is the primary language of business and administration; **Darija** (Moroccan Arabic) is used for daily life. English is common in top-tier hotels and among younger professionals.
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- **Social Graces**: Political discussions, particularly regarding the monarchy or Western Sahara, should be avoided. Expect business meetings to move at a slower, relationship-focused pace—patience is a virtue

Electricity:

Morocco uses Type C and Type E power outlets, which are the same standard European, two-round-pin sockets used in many other countries.
https://www.worldstandards.eu/electricity/plug-voltage-by-country/morocco/